anything to encourage greater participation of women in the country's economic life?

At Independence, India's female workforce was almost entirely uneducated and illiterate. Women worked primarily in homes, in their own agricultural fields or in traditional occupations like beedi-making. After Independence, India provided women the right to vote but did little to encourage their participation in the economic space. This, despite the fact that education for women became a focus area; by the turn of the century, elementary schooling of girls was virtually on a par with boys. In the past thirty years, an increasing number of women have gone to college and their tertiary education status has also improved substantially. Women are as economically productive as men are.

Two developments are primarily responsible for shrinking women's labour participation rates in the past fifteen years. One, as farms have become more mechanized, the need for manual work in fields has gone down. This has led to the displacement of female farm workers. Two, urban women, despite being much better educated and economically productive, have tended to be homemakers rather than working in factories, offices and establishments. This could be owing to implicit division of labour in the family, lack of appropriate jobs or the perception of risk to safety in urban areas or simply backward societal preference.

Policymakers seem to be quite unconcerned with this phenomenon. Nothing has been done to create incentives for establishment of labour-intensive factories in textile and other industries and encouraging participation of female workers. Bangladesh has created a far better framework for participation of women in the textile industry.

Certain decisions have been taken to increase benefits for working women. Paid maternity leave has been increased. Other benefits have also been improved. However, these measures do not seem to have encouraged greater employment of women.